

By Farzand Ahmed |

If the by-elections to 11 Assembly seats and the lone Lok Sabha seat of Firozabad were seen as a mini-General Election, the results would suggest that Uttar Pradesh is heading for a long spell of Mayawati's rule. The Bahujan Samaj Party's (BSP) jumbo continues to trundle, registering massive victories from Poorvanchal in the east to Bundelkhand in the south-west via the Doaba-Chambal belt of Central Zone that encompasses Etawah-Firozabad and the Terai region. The latest sweep where the BSP won nine of the 11 seats means that Mayawati has won 12 of the 15 bypolls held since August. In the process, she has consolidated her hold on the 403-member legislature. At the time of government formation in May 2007, the BSP had 206 MLAs. It now has 227.

As dramatic as Mayawati's sweeping victory was the drubbing of the Samajwadi Party (SP), which failed to win a single seat. For party supremo Mulayam Singh Yadav, who watched the results in Varanasi, the result was a numbing blow, especially in Firozabad where he had fielded his daughter-in-law Dimple Yadav against the Congress's Raj Babbar. The seat had been vacated by Dimple's husband Akhilesh Yadav. Firozabad was a matter of honour for two dynasties involved: the Gandhis and the Yadavs. In putting up Dimple, the Yadav father and son duo had virtually staked their family pride on the results of the bypolls. Dimple's candidature was seen as young Akhilesh's first test after taking over as the state president of the SP.

Dimple's defeat by over 85,000 votes is seen as proof that Akhilesh has a long way to go before he joins

the big league. His wife's defeat will hurt Mulayam all the more because it came at the hands of Babbar, a former SP Lok Sabha member from Agra who was hounded out of the party by sections of its leadership. In the May

elections, the SP had emerged on top, winning 23 of the 80 Lok Sabha seats from the state followed by the Congress with 21 and the BSP with 19. With the loss of Firozabad, the Congress and the SP are now tied at 22 seats apiece.

The Congress was quick to credit General Secretary Rahul Gandhi for the Firozabad win. Rahul had campaigned extensively for the filmstar-turned politician. His standing behind a party candidate was the first time

Dimple Yadav's defeat in Firozabad was a numbing blow for Mulayam, who had virtually staked his family honour by fielding her.

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Down on THE MAT

The bypolls have shown that the Mayawati magic endures and raises questions about the long-term prospects of the SP under Mulayam's son Akhilesh